

for individuals or dealers looking to sell old PCs.

Used computer = Beat up computer?

Not all used computers are ancient relics. Some traders just sell you an old PC 'as-is', without any support or warranty that the PC will run, while other vendors like Shah refurbish the used computers with new cabinets, keyboard and mouse and do a complete system test of all the parts before selling it.

Shah sources PCs from his existing customer base consisting of home users. "We buy back old PCs from customers who want to trade them for new systems. PCs sold off in lots by companies tend to be very old and redundant. In fact, 75 per cent of people who opt for secondhand PCs want at least a Pentium II or a Pentium III and don't mind spending a little more as long as they get a reliable PC."

What do I need to watch out for?

If you're buying a PC from a reliable source who can vouch for the condition of the PC, you won't have much of a problem. But if you're buying it from an unknown source, you should inspect the machine thor-

oughly before confirming the purchase.

While giving the PC a once over, check out what's inside the cabinet to ensure that the parts aren't damaged.

- Watch out for damaged motherboards. Tell tale signs would be jumpers with wires, or soldering work done on the motherboard. Make sure the 'goldfinger contacts' (those little gold bars) on the motherboard, RAM, or cards are not rusted and corroded.
- Make sure the heat sink fans on the

motherboards. Some dealers will give you what is known as a 'testing warranty', and let you test the PC in the store so that you're satisfied with the PC's performance (see box 'Test Drive before you Buy'). But it ends when you buy the PC and leave the store. Other dealers offer an eight to 10 day warranty.

Shah offers a 30-day warranty on the used PCs he sells, creating confidence in the customer's mind about the quality and reliability of the product.



Manoj Shah
USED COMPUTER BAZAAR,
MUMBAI

"We refurbish old PCs and provide a 30-day warranty as it helps create confidence in the mind of the consumer about the reliability of our product"

So, what do you do in case you don't get a warranty at all? Buy an AMC (Annual Maintenance Contract) for your secondhand PC, which will provide technical support in case there are any problems with the PC. An

AMC for a secondhand PC shouldn't cost you more than Rs 1,500-2,000.

Most AMCs only cover service. You could also buy a component inclusive AMC, which is quite expensive, but covers the cost of replacement of components. But if you're buying a PC that is more than three to four years old, finding replacements for components such as a 540 MB hard disk is virtually impossible.

At what point should you buy a new PC?

While a secondhand PC is a great buy, you need to watch your budget closely! Anything over Rs 15,000 for a secondhand PC (with AMC as an additional charge) means you should seriously consider whether you wouldn't be better off chipping in just a little more for a new PC with a full warranty!

It's difficult to predict how long a secondhand PC will last. It could last from a month to a year or two, provided it isn't too old—maybe two to three years old—and was kept in a dust free and humidity-free environment.

Ultimately, there will come a time when you'll have to say goodbye to your secondhand system and pack it off to a museum or the nearest scrap dealer. But till then there's no reason why you can't get the most out of your secondhand PC! ■

AVINA LOBO

Price Watch

Here's a look at what you can get at different price points*

Rs 5,000 A 486 with 8 MB RAM, 540 MB HDD, 1.44 MB floppy disk drive, monochrome VGA monitor, keyboard and mouse

Rs 10,000-11,000 Pentium 166 MMX with 32 MB RAM, 2.1 GB HDD, floppy disk drive, CD-ROM drive, soundcard, speakers, colour monitor, keyboard and mouse

Rs 12,000-13,000 Pentium II 300 MHz with 128 MB RAM, 8.4 GB HDD, CD-ROM drive, colour monitor, keyboard and mouse

Rs 15,000-16,000 Pentium III 500 MHz with 128 MB RAM, 8.4 GB HDD, CD-ROM drive, colour monitor, keyboard, and mouse

*These are approximate rates and have been compiled from several dealers in Mumbai. Actual rates might differ across cities.

motherboard are working and not clogged with dust. If they are, replacing them will cost you just Rs 500.

- Make sure the power supply fan works.

Ask the vendor for the configuration of the secondhand PC. Ideally, the best configuration to go for would be a processor running at 400 MHz with at least 64 MB RAM and a 4.3 GB hard disk. Your CD-ROM drive's speed should not be less than 24x or 32x. Apart from this, you should look out for:

■ **The motherboard:** This is an area where you should take particular care. Your best bet would be a motherboard not older than one-and-a-half to two years. The Intel 810 (or 815, 810e, 815e) motherboards are best as they support widely used processors such as Celeron and Pentium IIIs with clock speeds up to 700-800 MHz. Make sure the board has support for 133 MHz FSB (Front Side Bus) for later upgrades to increase processor power. Do not buy anything less than a 440BX chipset. Other cheaper motherboard alternatives are VIA 693, 694 and the Apollo Pro series.

■ **The monitor:** A monochrome VGA monitor will do just fine for data entry or word processing, and it will cost about Rs 1,000. A 14-inch colour monitor with a resolution of 800x600, on the other hand, should cost you Rs 3,000.

Will I get a warranty?

Secondhand PCs normally don't carry war-